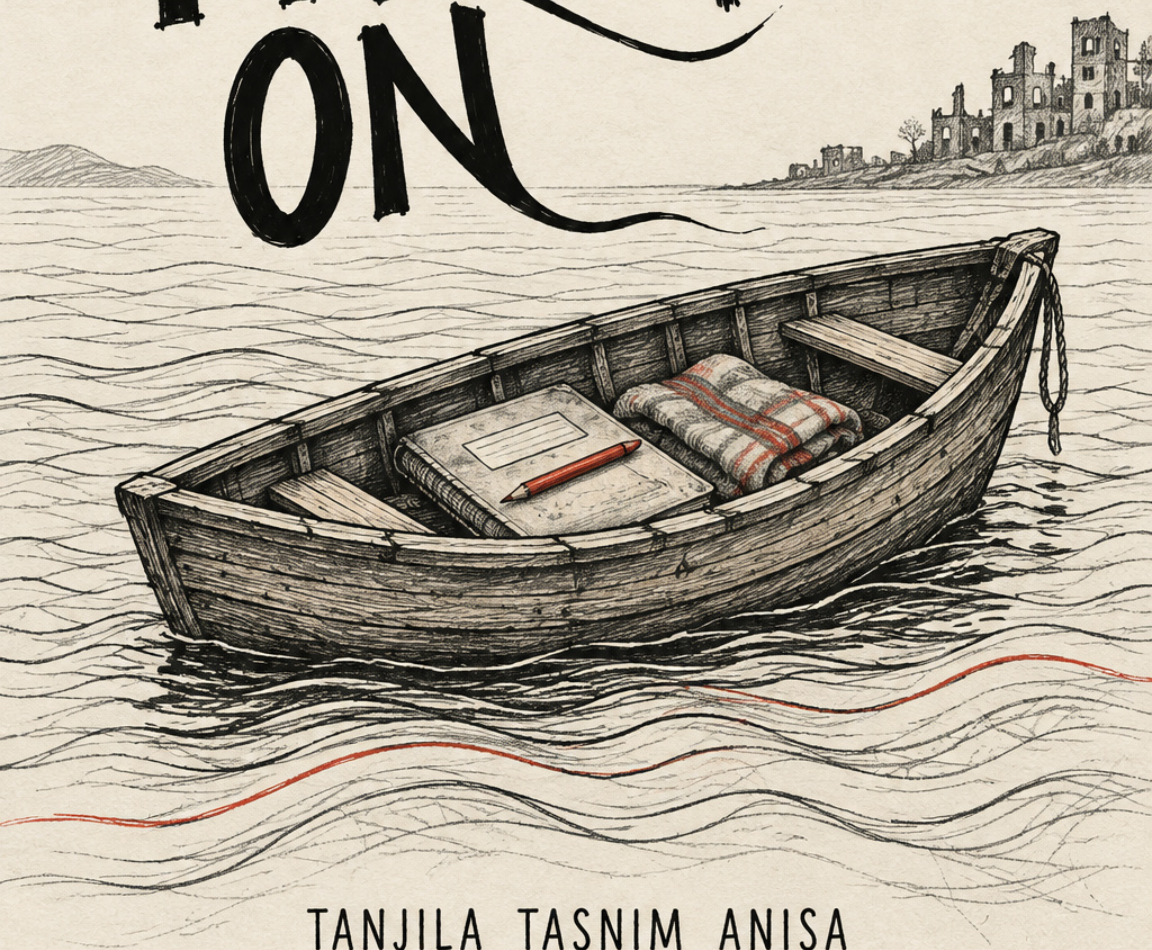


THE BOAT I FLOAT ON



TANJILA TASNIM ANISA

a story by

THE BOAT I FLOAT ON

Tanjila Tasnim Anisa

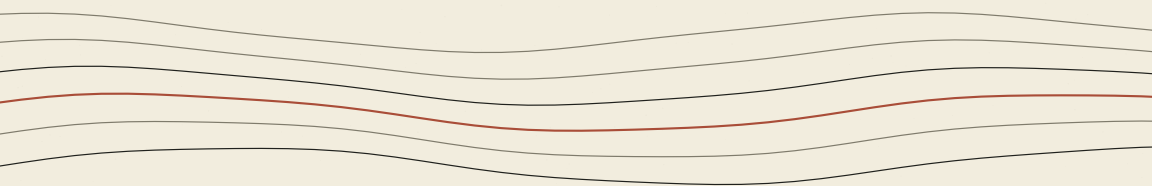


An illustrated reading edition

The boat is

TOO SMALL

to stretch my legs, but the sea has taught me not to complain. There are worse things than having nowhere to stretch your legs.



The sea is

FREEZING COLD.

Despite knowing how to swim, I sit still because I have never wanted to test that knowledge here. My Ma says cold is dangerous when you are small but never explained why do I even need to swim at the early stage of my life. So, for my own sanity, I stay on the boat.

I used to complain

about waking up early for school. My mother would pull the blanket from my face while I pretended to be asleep. My father would tell me that one day I would be grateful for every morning I was forced out of my bed.

morning / memory

Then the school

CLOSED FOREVER.

I had never understood that going to school was a privilege until someone decided I was no longer allowed to. The war as I mentioned as the “cruel sea” simply made the decision for me.

the page stops here

I KEEP MY SCHOOLBOOK BESIDE ME.



I haven't gone to school since the day we sailed from the shore. Its pages have begun to curl from the damp, but I still do the homework when there is enough light. Sometimes I draw on my sketchbook with my red pencil the only way I can relive the life I had before being on this boat.

We flinch at the slightest sound of wind, fearing it might be another airstrike. For a moment we forget that not every sound from the sky is meant to hurt us.

wind



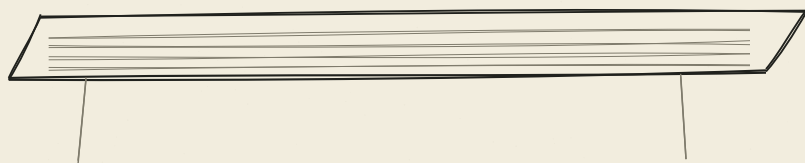
I used to know the sky differently. I
used to look up when I heard the
wind. I used to look for

CLOUDS,
BIRDS,

THE MOON.

Now I look for somewhere to hide.

As time passed, I realized I was all alone in the boat. Ma used to sit at the front of the boat because she said the wind was kinder there. Now that seat stays empty. My brother used to steal the blanket from me at night which I still leave half folded beside me.



The boat which once seemed
too small for me now became

EMPTY,

I guess I can stretch my legs
now.

Ma used to say “Cold is dangerous when you are small” but now there is nobody left to remind me how precious I am, perhaps I had never been just a mere child for the world instead I was a threat.

This time I decide to swim not because I want to reach to the shore. I swim because, for the first time, there is nothing left behind me to hold on to. The water is cold, but I have known colder things. Perhaps the world had mistaken my silence for surrender.

So, I leave the boat behind. Not because it was never my home, but because I refuse to let it become my grave. And as the waves carry me further, I finally understand what Ma meant. Cold is indeed dangerous when you are small.

the story continues beyond the page

But I am

NOT SMALL

anymore.

THE END

A SMALL BOAT. A SCHOOLBOOK. A RED PENCIL.

*A childhood changed by war, told
through the things a child keeps close.*

THE BOAT I FLOAT ON

Text by Tanjila Tasnim Anisa

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